

adoption not just of Western technological means but of Western political and financial systems, too.

Japan transformed

There followed a transformation of a kind no society had seen before or has seen since. Modeling itself on the West, in 30 years Japan became one of the most dynamic industrial powers in the world and the leading military power in East Asia.

Almost no aspect of Japanese society was left untouched by this whirlwind of change. In 1871, Japan abolished feudalism and established the yen as its currency. By 1872, the first railroad was under construction; within 15 years, there was 1,000 miles (1,600km) of track. In 1873, Japan introduced conscription, along with Western weapons and uniforms. The same year saw an overhaul of the education system, and in 1877 Japan's first university was established in Tokyo. Japan also introduced a new legal code in 1882, and a new constitution seven years later. As industry boomed, so exports grew. Cities similarly expanded, as did the population, swelling from 39.5 million in 1888 to 55 million by 1918.

The spur to modernization had largely been the fear that Japan, like China, would become another Western colonial pawn. In fact, the opposite occurred.



This image of Yokohama in 1874 depicts the modernity of Meiji-era Japan in the form of steam-powered trains and ships, which also served to open up the country to trade.

Military expansion

By the 1890s, Japan was a colonial power. In 1894, Korea had asked both Japan and China to help curb an insurrection there. When both countries later sought to take over Korea, the Japanese swept the Chinese aside, and then demanded and received possession of Taiwan, as well as rights in Manchuria. Here they came into conflict with Russia. The Japanese victory in 1905 over a disorganized Russian fleet at the Battle of Tsushima Strait was the first time an industrial European power had been defeated by an Asian power. Japan had the world's attention. ■

Emperor Meiji



Important not as a statesman or as the ruler of Japan in the sense of exercising actual power,

Emperor Meiji (1852–1912)—whose personal name, never used, was Mutsuhito—was instead the symbol of the reborn Japan. Until the restoration of Meiji in January 1868, the emperors of Japan were little more than a symbol. Under the shogunate, they were obliged to remain invisibly at the royal palace in Kyoto more or less permanently. Strictly speaking, the “restoration” never happened: Meiji had already become emperor in February 1867, following the sudden death of his father, Emperor Komei.

For those ambitious *daimyo*, or feudal barons, who were determined to drive Japan into the modern world, elevating the emperor to a higher profile bestowed legitimacy on what was otherwise an act of usurpation. It is telling that one of their first acts was to force the emperor to move to Edo, which was renamed Tokyo in 1868, the former residence of the shogun. Meiji himself remained an impenetrable cypher to the end.